

# Caym, from Real Combat to the Spiritual Path

Nice (Alpes-Maritimes) – Born in 1962 on the French Riviera, Caym has followed a singular trajectory at the crossroads of martial arts, marginal subcultures, and literature. Long associated with a harsh and sometimes violent world, he now embodies a radically different figure: a man devoted to transmission, writing, and inner exploration.

His adolescence was marked by a strong attraction to underground milieus and an early confrontation with violence. At the age of 15, he associated with Bruno Mancini, known as *Nono le Sarde*, a young figure of Marseille's criminal underworld whose appearance and codes evoked gangsters of another era. This period coincided with his intensive practice of *brancaille*, a combat discipline combining boxing and wrestling, in which Caym forged a reputation as a resilient fighter accustomed to direct confrontations, often against physically stronger opponents.

At 16, he joined a group of young Asian martial arts practitioners known for testing their techniques in real, non-codified situations. These repeated and sometimes brutal experiences helped shape a relationship to the body and to risk grounded in trial and confrontation. The following year, an encounter with an Indian master specializing in *vajramushti-yuddha*, a traditional martial art, introduced a more structured and spiritual dimension to his path. This mentor, also a musician and spiritual guide, had a lasting influence on Caym, who subsequently founded the rock band **Blakrystal**. The experience was short-lived: he quickly realized that his path lay more in combat than in musical creation.

The nickname "Caym" was given to him during this period by Mike "Lugh" Doherty, leader of the *Clann na Morrigan*, a group of itinerant Irish bikers reputed for their violence. This proximity contributed to a sulphurous reputation, although no evidence establishes any direct involvement in criminal activities.

A serious accident during a competition in 1988 marked a decisive turning point. Injured, Caym entered a phase of introspection that gradually distanced him from the logic of domination and confrontation that had shaped his youth. He then devoted himself to writing, teaching, meditation, and an openly embraced spiritual quest, seeking to transform accumulated violent energy into inner discipline. The Japanese swordsman Miyamoto Musashi became one of his principal sources of inspiration.

In 1990, he took part in the creation of modern *pancrase*, a contemporary adaptation of ancient *pankration* incorporating the principles of *brancaille*. He organized several free-fighting tournaments abroad, as such practices were prohibited in France at the time.

In 2003, Caym definitively put an end to his practice of martial arts. He turned away from physical confrontation to devote himself exclusively to inner and intellectual work.

Now over 50 years old, he presents a striking contrast with the man he once was: calm, measured, and far removed from any display of force. His journey illustrates a marked evolution, in which a youth shaped by violence and excess gradually gave way to a search for meaning and balance. An atypical trajectory, yet one that reveals a profound transformation.

*Alzira dos Santos, March 17, 2014*